Daniel Manginelli

GAME DESIGNER · SYSTEMS, CONTENT & COMBAT DESIGN

Recife, Brazil · Open to relocation
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Featured: Mars Incremental on Steam · store.steampowered.com/app/4179880

SUMMARY

Game designer with over eight years in games and nine shipped titles on Steam and mobile, designing gameplay systems, combat, content, progression and economies. I own features end to end, from the experience a player should have to the specs, spreadsheets and prototypes that make it happen, and tune them through playtests, data and critique. I believe the best games come from care, study and iteration.

EXPERIENCE

Co-Founder · Creative Director & Game Designer, *Pixel Hound Studios* — Apr 2024 - Present · Recife

- Lead game designer on **Mars Incremental** (Steam, 2027): core loop, economy, progression and a unique mechanic for each building; built and tuned its game data in spreadsheets (tables of up to 500 entries) through playtests, and graded its talents with a balance simulator built from the game's code with AI assistance (Claude)
- Lead game designer on **Across the Abyss: Voidborn** (Steam, 2024): took an existing prototype to launch, designing the combat (defeated enemies become bombs that chain through the crowd) and the elemental system
- Designed every boss and enemy in Voidborn, their attacks and weaknesses, balanced across both stages, wrote its three companion characters, and took the game through the full publishing process
- Guide the art team on decisions that shape the player-facing experience; presented the game's design in publisher pitches
- Built the studio's development process from scratch: design docs, sprint planning and a playtest loop that guides balancing

Senior Game Designer, *Hoplon* — Oct 2022 - Jun 2024 · Remote

- Shipped seven mobile games on Google Play with publishers (since delisted), five of them as lead designer, taking features from high concept and GDD through implementation with engineers, artists and QA to post-launch balancing
- Iterated on mechanics with data-driven workflows, based on soft launch metrics and publisher feedback
- Designed **Mutant Combat Merge**, an idle combat game with merge mechanics, biome bosses and an hour of balanced progression
- Tuned **Hex Conquest**'s AI to feel threatening while favoring the player, plus adaptive difficulty

Game Designer, *PUGA Studios* — Jan 2020 - Oct 2022 · Recife

- Lead designer of a midcore mobile game: economy, battle system, content, UI/UX and balancing (NDA)
- Modeled game economies and rewards in spreadsheets, projecting earnings for different player types over time and rebalancing as features were added
- Level designer on a PC indie, including procedurally generated levels

Earlier: Game Design Intern, PUGA Studios (2018): lead designer of *Carnavalência*, a mobile arcade game made with Brazil's Ministry of Culture · Design Intern, CESAR (2018) · Game Developer, Diorama Digital (2016 - 2017): sole programmer of a mobile infinite runner and a mobile VR experience

PERSONAL PROJECTS · DANNY'S TINKER LAB

Forever Class Lab (2026, beta): talent calculator and class tester for every WoW: Forever class, built from public beta data, with damage, tank and healing tests

Demon Hunter: a class reimagining for WoW: Forever (2026, manginelli.github.io/demon-hunter): full class design with three specializations, a core combat mechanic that rewards constant pressure, original lore, and a four-wave playable browser stage built with AI-assisted development (Claude)

MangiUI: a minimal UI preset for ultrawide screens, shared with the community

SKILLS & TOOLS

Design: gameplay systems, combat design, content and level design, enemy and boss design, class design, rewards and progression, economy and balancing, AI and difficulty tuning, rapid prototyping, design documentation

Data: data-driven workflows, economy modeling in spreadsheets, soft launch metrics, playtest analysis

Tools: Godot, Unity, Unreal Engine, C#, Git/GitHub, Google Sheets, Jira, Notion, Miro, Claude (AI-assisted prototyping and tools)

EDUCATION, AWARDS & LANGUAGES

Education: Bachelor's Degree in Design, CESAR School (2018 - 2022) · Bachelor's Degree in Law, UFPE (2012 - 2017)

Awards: SBGames 2022 Best Papers, 3rd place short paper in Arts & Design (emergent behavior in Elden Ring) · GameJamPlus Recife 2019, 1st place (*Statue Knight*)

Languages: Portuguese (native) · English (full professional proficiency)